

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Cross-Cultural Leadership English

Conversation lab

8 complete workplace dialogues, followed by eight additional role-play cases. Study the exchanges, then make the conversation your own.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Find the right language. Speak, write, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For managers, cross-border teams, HR partners, and meeting facilitators.

Ask about individual preferences and team norms. Nationality, accent, silence, or directness does not tell you what a person believes or how they will behave.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

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Inside this conversation lab

Original fictional training conversations in professional English. These are realistic scripts, not transcripts of actual people. The professional roles are the speaker labels; all figures, incidents, and organizations are invented.

01 Checking apparent agreement

02 Disagreeing with a proposal

03 Decision rights

04 Negotiating a reporting deadline

05 Including a remote colleague

06 Specific performance feedback

07 Coordinating across time zones

08 Repairing an interruption

Then try eight independent role-play cases, followed by feedback criteria and references.

Read it. Hear it. Make it yours.

1. Read the setting. Identify the roles, the immediate problem, and what each speaker needs.
2. Read the whole conversation aloud with a partner. In a group, give a third person the observer role. For three-speaker scripts, assign each professional a separate voice.
3. Notice how the speakers ask a specific question, qualify a claim, disagree, explain a technical point, or agree on a next step. Underline language you would actually use.
4. Cover the script. Recreate the exchange using the situation and professional roles. Keep the meaning, but change the wording.
5. Switch roles and introduce a complication: a missing record, a different priority, an unavailable colleague, or a changed assumption. End with a clear outcome or unresolved question.

Register and terminology

These colleagues use concise professional language. In an internal technical meeting, familiar abbreviations can be natural. With a new colleague or a client, expand unfamiliar terms and check understanding. Keep disagreement directed at the evidence or proposal, and match the degree of certainty to what is known.

Independent study

Speak each role aloud. Pause before the reply and supply your own response before revealing the next line. Record a second version using invented details, then compare its clarity and tone with the script.

Professional context

Ask about individual preferences and team norms. Nationality, accent, silence, or directness does not tell you what a person believes or how they will behave.

FULL DIALOGUE 01 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Checking apparent agreement

A branch team revisits a launch discussion.

Roles: Branch manager / Operations lead / Project coordinator

Branch manager: I recorded agreement on Friday's launch, but your note raises a staffing concern. Did I misunderstand?

Operations lead: I agreed the plan was workable in principle, not that staffing was confirmed.

Project coordinator: My minutes didn't preserve that distinction. I'll correct the record.

Branch manager: Thanks. What needs to be resolved before we can commit to the date?

Operations lead: Weekend coverage and an escalation contact. I'll bring two staffing options tomorrow.

Branch manager: Then the date remains proposed. We'll make the decision after reviewing those options together.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "I recorded agreement on Friday's launch, but your note raises a staffing concern. Did I misunderstand?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 02 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Disagreeing with a proposal

A facilitator addresses a blunt objection in a planning meeting.

Roles: Meeting facilitator / Technical lead / Commercial lead

Meeting facilitator: Let's return to your concern about the proposal. Which assumption doesn't hold?

Technical lead: The estimate assumes the integration is already available. It isn't.

Commercial lead: I hadn't seen that dependency. How does it affect the delivery options?

Technical lead: We can test a manual workflow first, or wait for the integration. The effort differs substantially.

Meeting facilitator: Please compare those options. We can challenge the assumption without dismissing the people who prepared the plan.

Commercial lead: I'll update the commercial timeline once we've reviewed the technical evidence.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "Let's return to your concern about the proposal. Which assumption doesn't hold?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 03 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Decision rights

A new project team clarifies who can approve resources.

Roles: Team manager / Project lead / HR partner

Team manager: I want recommendations from the team, but I hold the final staffing decision.

Project lead: Can workstream leads negotiate allocations directly with one another?

Team manager: You can develop options. Please bring any change affecting approved capacity back for a decision.

HR partner: I'll make that boundary clear in the team charter, including the escalation route.

Project lead: That helps. I'll gather the options before Friday rather than present an allocation as already approved.

Team manager: Good. I'll explain the decision and the tradeoffs after everyone's input has been considered.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "Can workstream leads negotiate allocations directly with one another?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 04 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Negotiating a reporting deadline

Headquarters needs figures before the branch can verify them.

Roles: Headquarters analyst / Branch finance lead

Headquarters analyst: We need the figures on Friday for the leadership pack. Can you confirm?

Branch finance lead: Verified figures will be ready Monday. I can provide a clearly labeled estimate on Friday.

Headquarters analyst: Which entries remain uncertain, and how material could they be?

Branch finance lead: Two supplier accruals. I'll show the assumptions and the range still under review.

Headquarters analyst: Send that provisional view Friday, then the verified update Monday.

Branch finance lead: Agreed. I'll label the versions clearly so the estimate isn't circulated as the final close.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "We need the figures on Friday for the leadership pack. Can you confirm?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 05 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Including a remote colleague

A hybrid meeting has moved past an unheard concern.

Roles: Facilitator / Remote analyst / Team lead

Facilitator: We missed the question in chat. Priya, please take us through it before we decide.

Remote analyst: The proposed date conflicts with the data refresh. Our dashboard would still show last month's figures.

Team lead: That's relevant. Could we refresh early?

Remote analyst: Only if the source team can provide a complete extract. I need to check.

Facilitator: Let's record that dependency. We don't have agreement on a final date yet.

Team lead: I'll coordinate the source-team response and bring it back to the group.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "That's relevant. Could we refresh early?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 06 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Specific performance feedback

A manager discusses two late reports with a colleague.

Roles: Manager / Reporting analyst

Manager: The last two reports arrived Tuesday rather than Monday, which delayed the review. What's getting in the way?

Reporting analyst: The source team sends corrections Monday afternoon. I wait because I don't want to publish errors.

Manager: That makes sense. Could an earlier exception report flag what is still provisional?

Reporting analyst: Yes, if we agree what can remain open and how it's labeled.

Manager: Let's review that with the source team and set a workable process.

Reporting analyst: I'll bring examples of the corrections so we can design around the actual problem.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "The last two reports arrived Tuesday rather than Monday, which delayed the review. What's getting in the way?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 07 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Coordinating across time zones

Two office leads negotiate a recurring meeting.

Roles: Regional lead / Headquarters project lead

Regional lead: The current meeting falls outside my team's working hours every week.

Headquarters project lead: I hadn't realized the burden was always on the same group. What overlap do we have?

Regional lead: A short window on Tuesdays. Some status updates could also be asynchronous.

Headquarters project lead: Let's use that window for decisions and send routine updates in advance.

Regional lead: I'll ask the team about specific availability rather than assume one arrangement works for everyone.

Headquarters project lead: We'll trial the schedule for a month and review participation and decision speed.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "I hadn't realized the burden was always on the same group. What overlap do we have?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 08 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Repairing an interruption

A manager revisits a conversation with a colleague.

Roles: Manager / Program coordinator

Manager: I interrupted you twice during the review. I'm sorry; I didn't hear your full concern.

Program coordinator: I was trying to explain that the local partner hadn't accepted the revised responsibilities.

Manager: Please finish that explanation now. Which responsibilities are still unresolved?

Program coordinator: Participant follow-up and reporting. We need their agreement before recording the handover as complete.

Manager: I'll correct the status and give that issue time at the next meeting.

Program coordinator: Thank you. I'll prepare the open points so the discussion can reach a clear next step.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "Please finish that explanation now. Which responsibilities are still unresolved?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

Eight more situations to make your own

The following cases are open role plays. They give you facts, contrasting roles, useful expressions, and a short model response. Use what you learned from the complete dialogues to create a longer exchange.

Preparation: two minutes. Conversation: three to five minutes. Feedback: one minute. Switch roles and repeat with the second-round challenge.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 01

Check meaning before assuming agreement

SHARED CASE

In a branch meeting, two colleagues say the launch plan is "fine." One later emails a concern about staffing. The manager had recorded agreement.

Role A | Responding professional

Clarify missing information before responding. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Useful expressions

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is Is that right?

Cover this until after your first attempt

When you said the plan was fine, did you mean you supported the date or still had concerns? Let's check each person's view before I record a decision.

Second round

The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 02

Challenge ideas respectfully

SHARED CASE

A colleague says, "This proposal makes no sense." The group goes quiet. You want to hear the concern without accepting personal attacks.

Role A | Responding professional

State a concern respectfully and propose a practical route forward. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You want to move quickly and initially overlook a relevant condition. Ask why it matters, then consider a practical route forward that respects the real constraint.

Useful expressions

I understand the goal. My concern is

That statement goes beyond

Could we ... before confirming ...?

Cover this until after your first attempt

I'd like to understand the objection. Which assumption do you disagree with? Please focus on the proposal so we can examine it together.

Second round

The other person repeats the request more firmly. Restate the specific concern calmly and explain the appropriate next route.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 03

Make authority and participation clear

SHARED CASE

Your team wants more direction, but the manager has been answering every question. A new hire has stopped offering ideas.

Role A | Responding professional

Include relevant voices and clarify the decision process. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You hold a relevant concern that has not been discussed. Raise it when invited and ask who will decide. Help the facilitator state one unresolved question accurately.

Useful expressions

Let's hear ... before we decide.

The point we still need to resolve is

Who will make this decision, and what do they need?

Cover this until after your first attempt

I'll make the final decision on staffing. Before that, I want each of you to suggest one option. You can speak now or send a note after the meeting.

Second round

A participant interrupts or the meeting is running out of time. Protect a turn to speak and close with an accurate decision record.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 04

Negotiate realistic commitments

SHARED CASE

Headquarters asks for a report on Friday. The local team can produce verified figures on Monday or a clearly labeled estimate on Friday.

Role A | Responding professional

Negotiate scope or timing while making conditions explicit. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You want the preferred outcome but can accept one tradeoff. Ask for two options, then state which condition you can accept and which still needs approval.

Useful expressions

We can ..., provided that

Would you prefer ... or ...?

I can take that proposal for review; I cannot yet confirm

Cover this until after your first attempt

We can send an estimate on Friday or verified figures on Monday. Which would meet your need? If we send the estimate, I'll label the figures as provisional.

Second round

The preferred option is unavailable. Offer an alternative and clearly state any approval still needed.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 05

Include every voice in a meeting

SHARED CASE

Three people speak at once during a hybrid meeting. A remote colleague's question is missed, and nobody knows who can approve the plan.

Role A | Responding professional

Include relevant voices and clarify the decision process. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You hold a relevant concern that has not been discussed. Raise it when invited and ask who will decide. Help the facilitator state one unresolved question accurately.

Useful expressions

Let's hear ... before we decide.

The point we still need to resolve is

Who will make this decision, and what do they need?

Cover this until after your first attempt

Let's hear Morgan's question first. Then we'll take one comment at a time. Before we finish, can we confirm who approves the plan and when?

Second round

A participant interrupts or the meeting is running out of time. Protect a turn to speak and close with an accurate decision record.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 06

Give specific, useful feedback

SHARED CASE

Two weekly reports arrived a day after the agreed deadline. The manager does not know the reason. Other teams depend on the figures.

Role A | Responding professional

Describe observed behavior, its effect, and a useful next step. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You can explain a practical obstacle affecting the work. Share it after your partner asks for your perspective, then agree on one observable change.

Useful expressions

In [specific situation], I noticed ...

The effect was ... What was happening from your perspective?

Could we agree to ... and review it ...?

Cover this until after your first attempt

The last two reports arrived on Tuesday instead of Monday. That delayed our review. What is getting in the way, and what support would help you meet Monday's deadline?

Second round

The recipient disagrees with your interpretation. Return to the observed example, listen, and revise an unsupported assumption.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 07

Coordinate across offices

SHARED CASE

Headquarters requests daily detail. The branch says the reporting takes an hour each day. Neither side has explained what information it actually needs.

Role A | Responding professional

Explain a useful distinction in plain English. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You are unfamiliar with one technical term in the case. Ask for a plain-English explanation and then paraphrase it. Do not pretend to understand a term you cannot explain.

Useful expressions

In this context, ... means

The difference is that

How would you explain that distinction to a colleague?

Cover this until after your first attempt

Headquarters needs early notice of delays; the branch needs time to deliver the work. Could we try a short daily exception report and review the arrangement in two weeks?

Second round

Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 08

Repair misunderstandings and build trust

SHARED CASE

You interrupted a colleague twice while they explained a concern. They later say they felt dismissed. The concern is still unresolved.

Role A | Responding professional

Acknowledge a communication problem and give a corrected message. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You are frustrated because an earlier message created an expectation. Explain that expectation. Ask your partner to distinguish the correction from anything still uncertain.

Useful expressions

My earlier message did not make ... clear.

I'm sorry for The correct information is

Let me check that the revised explanation addresses

Cover this until after your first attempt

I interrupted you and missed part of your concern. I'm sorry. Could we return to it now?
At our next meeting, I'll let you finish before I respond.

Second round

The listener remains disappointed after the correction. Acknowledge the impact and restate the available next step calmly.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and writes a 70-110 word message. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

Ask about individual preferences and team norms. Nationality, accent, silence, or directness does not tell you what a person believes or how they will behave.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.